

FIELD LIBRARY / FULL FIELD GUIDE

Damaging winds

NATURAL HAZARDS / EDITION 2026-10-02

QUICK ANSWER / START HERE

Shelter inside a sturdy building away from windows when damaging winds threaten. Avoid trees, power lines and lightweight structures. Follow tornado warnings separately; straight-line winds can also cause severe damage.

Do now.

**Secure items beforehand**

01

Bring loose items inside while conditions are calm; do not go out once winds are dangerous.

**Use an interior room**

02

Stay away from glass and large exterior openings.

**Limit driving**

03

High-profile vehicles are vulnerable; avoid routes lined with falling trees or debris.

**Keep clear afterward**

04

Assume downed lines are live and report them from a safe distance.

Keep the plan moving.

IF HELP IS UNAVAILABLE

Wait for winds to ease in the best shelter you can reach without exposure. Keep a torch and shoes nearby for broken glass. If the building is failing, move to a safer reachable space without going beneath trees, loose roofing or wires.

Watch for.

Do not attempt to clear a tree from a power line.

People & practical needs.

Account for children, older people, pets and anyone who needs assistance before moving. Keep shoes, medicines and a torch in the shelter area. Decide who helps whom and who carries the essential supplies; do not send a lone child to retrieve items. For this situation, brief every person on the first action: secure items beforehand. Agree who will manage children, pets or mobility needs while that action happens. Do not attempt to clear a tree from a power line.

Keep essentials within reach.

For damaging winds, prioritize only items needed for the first action and the fallback: Wait for winds to ease in the best shelter you can reach without exposure. Keep a torch and shoes nearby for broken glass. If the building is failing, move to a safer reachable space without going beneath trees, loose roofing or wires. Keep the relevant checklist and contact information within reach. Equipment retrieval must not delay the protective step.

Next decisions.

Inspect damage without entering unstable buildings. Arrange help for trees touching wires.

First decision: Secure items beforehand

Bring loose items inside while conditions are calm; do not go out once winds are dangerous. Decide which person can carry this out immediately and what would prevent it in your current location. Do not delay the protective step to complete a household worksheet.

When the original plan fails

Wait for winds to ease in the best shelter you can reach without exposure. Keep a torch and shoes nearby for broken glass. If the building is failing, move to a safer reachable space without going beneath trees, loose roofing or wires. Reassess the next available location or resource using the warning signs in this guide; do not assume a promised service is operating.

Before changing location

Do not attempt to clear a tree from a power line. Check the actual route and the needs of the person who will have the most difficulty moving. A destination is not confirmed until access and conditions have been checked.

Questions in the field.

What matters before collecting supplies?

Shelter inside a sturdy building away from windows when damaging winds threaten. Avoid trees, power lines and lightweight structures. Follow tornado warnings separately; straight-line winds can also cause severe damage. Collect items only if doing so does not delay this action.

What should another household member do?

Use a second person to handle communication or dependents while the first carries out the immediate action. For damaging winds, keep the specific hazard in view: Do not attempt to clear a tree from a power line.

What should be written down?

Record when the situation changed, what action was taken and what remains uncertain. For this situation, start with: Keep clear afterward. Assume downed lines are live and report them from a safe distance. Keep personal notes private; they are not submitted to Osprey Zero.

YOUR SITUATION / PRIVATE WORKSHEET

TIME / LOCATION / CHANGING CONDITIONS

PEOPLE / ACCESS OR MEDICAL NEEDS

NEXT ACTION / PERSON RESPONSIBLE

Sources & limits.

Civilian educational guidance. Linked references may use U.S. emergency systems; local warning methods, laws, services and conditions differ.

Source-linked editorial guidance. Not independent clinical or specialist certification. Training and product-specific instructions remain essential.

Damaging winds · official guidance

<https://www.weather.gov/safety/wind>

Full guide: <https://ospreyzero.com/emergencies/damaging-winds/>

Content updated 2026-10-02. Saved guidance cannot provide live alerts.